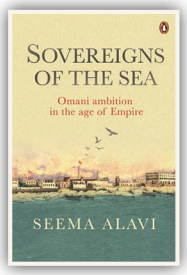
BOOKS

Nautical Natives

Seema Alavi provides a refreshing non-European perspective on the Indian Ocean in the Age of Empire

The author is a distinguished historian of 18th- and 19th-century India and, in this work, has widened her frame to look at the Western Indian Ocean in the 19th century. In doing so, she situates herself as part of a historiographical tradition that looks beneath the surface of the very evident European, and increasingly British, domination of these waters in order to relate a history in which indigenous and native actors play more substantive roles than as allies or supplicants of the British. The Indian Ocean in the 19th century then becomes more than a monochromatic space dominated by external powers, to a more crowded maritime terrain in which a host of local and regional players cooperate and jostle to maximise their autonomy from the increasing demands of an expanding British imperialism.



SOVEREIGNS OF THE SEA: Omani Ambition in the Age of Empire
by Seema Alavi
PENGUIN
₹999; 424 pages

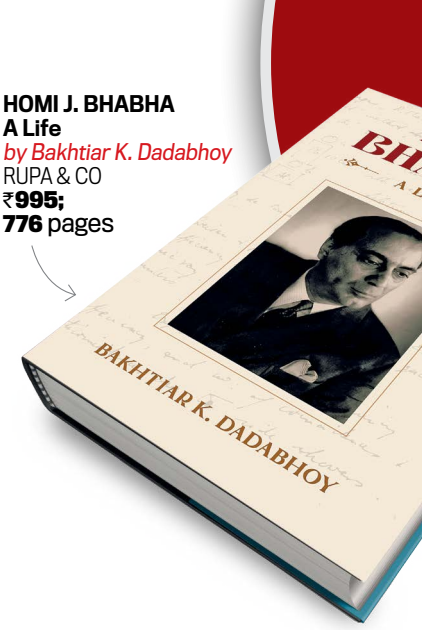
Dr Alavi's focus is on a single family that provided Oman five of its sultans over the 19th century till it became a British protectorate. But till that happened, these sultans were acting as powers in their own right, often "engaged with the Western powers from a position of strength", which "made them visible as significant Arab imperialists" in an "assemblage of powers normally viewed as the white man's club".

For each sultan, the area of interest and influence was a significant arc of the Western Indian Ocean, extending from Bandar Abbas deep inside the Persian Gulf, to the Makran Coast, India's western coast and all the way to Zanzibar on Africa's east coast. Zanzibar was of particular importance because it was part of the single sultanate of Oman till its bifurcation into Zanzibar and Muscat, each under a sibling frequently in collision. Traders from India, Bedouin tribes from the interior of Oman, Swahili chiefs from the African coast, the Wahabis in the Arabian Peninsula, Persian nobility and Baluchi chiefs are among the constituencies that populated their universe. While often preoccupied by family feuds and internecine conflicts, each sultan also interfaced with the British, seeking to leverage them to their advantage while also keeping this overbearing power from prying too closely into their affairs.

British phobia about the Wahabis and their interest in laying a telegraph line were among the issues that the Omani sultans could effectively leverage in the British scheme of things. Slavery and the slave trade, however, were viewed through their own local prism and they strongly resisted British efforts to regulate and then ban the trade. Even as the issue gathered traction after the 1850s, the sultans dexterously warded off these pressures through a number of modalities. That British persons and entities were, despite the rhetoric, major beneficiaries from slaves, made it that much more feasible.

This is a book packed with fascinating detail: how city planning in Bombay provided Sultan Sayyid Majid (1834-70) with the template for a new capital in Zanzibar—Dar es Salaam; the pivotal role of Indians from Kutch in the slave trade, etc. It admirably succeeds in providing a non-Eurocentric perspective on the Indian Ocean in this period. For the general reader, however, this refreshing narrative could have been made more accessible with a map and, finally, given this relatively unknown universe, readers would have liked to know how and why this 'Omani ambition in the age of Empire' finally drew to a close with both Zanzibar and Oman becoming British protectorates. ■

T.C.A. Raghavan



HOMI J. BHABHA
A Life
by Bakhtiar K. Dadabhoy
RUPA & CO
₹995;
776 pages

When Jehangir and Meherbai Bhabha visited Paris in 1913, they added an unconventional stop to their itinerary. Worried that their four-year-old son slept too little, they took him to a famous paediatrician. After meeting little Hormusji, the doctor cancelled his other appointments and spent time chatting with his new patient. He told the Bhabhas that their son had an extraordinarily active brain that made sleep difficult. Given the right environment, the boy would grow up a genius.

BOOKS

The Hills Are Alive

Lekhnath Chhetri's award-winning Nepali novel is set in the 1980s, a turbulent time for the Darjeeling hills

"Learn the alphabet and become someone who tells his own story" is Basnet's advice to his son Jhuppay early on in the novel. Jhuppay, the truant and thief, does not heed it, but his actions lead the story forward—to disastrous consequences for his family, the family of Nimma, the woman he